

Comprehensive cat aggression handbook with evidence-based prevention and management strategies — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

CLASSIFY AND DIAGNOSE

- ☐ **Classify and Diagnose, Item 1:** Identify whether your cat's attacks stem from play, fear, petting-induced, territorial, redirected, pain-related, or status-related aggression. Getting the classification right determines which solution will actually work for your situation.
- ☐ **Classify and Diagnose, Item 2:** Track attack timing, location, preceding activity, body parts targeted, and intensity level for five separate incidents. Writing down these details helps you identify patterns that reveal the aggression type.
- ☐ **Classify and Diagnose, Item 3:** Check your cat for pain indicators including new or worsening aggression, biting when specific areas are touched, and reluctance to be handled in certain positions. Pain-induced aggression requires veterinary diagnosis before behavior modification can succeed.
- ☐ **Classify and Diagnose, Item 4:** Distinguish predatory aggression from fear or status aggression by noting whether attacks involve silent stalking, hidden positioning, and neck or shoulder targeting. Predatory attacks follow instinct rather than emotional state.

READ AND INTERCEPT

- ☐ **Read and Intercept, Item 1:** Watch for pre-attack body language signals before every petting session including tail flicking, skin rippling, sideways ear rotation, and pupil dilation. These signals appear within seconds and indicate your cat's tolerance threshold is being reached.
 - ☐ **Read and Intercept, Item 2:** Stop petting immediately and give your cat space when you notice any skin rippling, tail lashing, or head turning toward your hand. Continuing through these signals is the most common trigger for sudden petting-induced bites.
-

- ☐ **Read and Intercept, Item 3:** Learn the difference between defensive and offensive postures by watching for crouching or rolling onto the back with flattened sideways ears. This is a prepare-to-fight posture that can escalate to serious injury if misread as affection.
-

- ☐ **Read and Intercept, Item 4:** Note whether your cat has been exposed to triggers they could not access such as outdoor cats at windows, loud noises, or environmental changes. Redirected aggression often appears without warning in otherwise calm cats and persists for hours after the initial trigger.

PREVENT AND MANAGE

- ☐ **Prevent and Manage, Item 1:** Provide structured daily play sessions using wand toys that mimic prey movement rather than allowing hands or feet to serve as targets. Redirecting predatory energy toward appropriate toys eliminates the association between hands and hunting satisfaction.
-

- ☐ **Prevent and Manage, Item 2:** Make environmental changes to reduce ambush opportunities by closing doors to rooms where attacks occur, using baby gates to create safe zones, and providing elevated resting areas. Restructuring your home removes the elements that make surprise attacks possible.
-

- ☐ **Prevent and Manage, Item 3:** Allow hyperaroused cats a 24 to 72-hour decompression period in a separate room with food, water, and litter. This prevents redirected aggression from persisting or escalating when the cat cannot self-regulate.
-

- ☐ **Prevent and Manage, Item 4:** Schedule a veterinary examination when aggression is new, escalating, or linked to potential pain indicators. Medical conditions must be ruled out before behavior modification alone can resolve the problem.
-

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.